

AI in 2026 — Pocket cheat sheet

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HOW AI WORKS

The Plinko model.

AI is **probabilistic**, not deterministic. Your prompt drops into a Plinko board, bounces through billions of weighted pegs, and lands somewhere.

Same prompt → different output every time. Treat each response as a draw from a distribution, not as *the* answer.

Hallucinations aren't a bug — they're the feature. The same mechanism that makes AI creative is what makes it wrong.

WHERE TO START

Expertise × Attention.

STARTER ZONE — high expertise + high attention. Amplify your strengths. Start with hobbies and areas of expertise.

Teach me — low expertise + high attention. Learn with it.

Systematize — high expertise + low attention. Custom GPTs / gems.

DANGER ZONE — low + low. Don't go here without being cautious and aware of the pitfalls

WHAT YOU OFFLOAD

Narrow, not broad.

Broad offload — hand it the whole task. Skills decline in about three months.

Narrow offload — hand off the friction, keep the thinking.

AI should eat **extraneous** difficulty (formatting, hunting for information), not **germane** difficulty (the productive struggle that builds skill).

Bench press, dolly, forklift. Pick the right tool for the lift.

BEFORE YOU TRUST IT

Three questions.

1. Is this a problem AI can actually solve?
2. Does the model have enough good data to solve it?
3. How close is the output to the real world I live in?

Your expertise, in your context, is your only real edge. Bring it.